# Everyone deserves access to CANCER CARE

- Cancer is one of the leading causes of morbidity and mortality worldwide, with approximately 19million new cases in 2020 in the world.
- Cancer is the second leading cause of death globally and was responsible for 9.9 million deaths in 2020.

India is not far in this league 1.3 million new cases of cancer and more than 8 lakhs of deaths.

Cancer is not only a health concern, it is a complex issue that also involves social, economic, developmental, and human rights. The numbers listed above are alarming and people around the world to be aware that a cancer diagnosis is not a death sentence. Today, some cancers that were once considered deadly are treatable and, in some cases, curable. The advancements in understanding risk factors, along with prevention, early detection and rapid treatment have improved cancer management.

Healthcare systems around the world are continuously evolving. Personalized medicine, popularly known as precision medicine in oncology, is one such approach that different healthcare systems around the world are trying to incorporate into their current medical practice as much as they can.

Currently, a cancer patient is required to undergo extensive testing to identify the extent, stage, and grade of cancer. Based on the reports, a team of oncologists decides the course of treatment. Every patient is likely to receive a combination of treatment, which may include chemotherapy, surgery, radiation therapy, immunotherapy, or hormonal therapy.

Even though it is now known that specific genetic changes in the cells cause cancer. However, genetic testing to identify the type of changes in the DNA of the cells is not conducted for every patient. In fact, they are made to undergo several cycles of chemotherapy and radiation therapy, following surgery.

This is partly because there is no way for the doctors to identify individual treatment for each patient. Therefore, they follow a standardized and most common approach for cancer treatment.

Currently cancer treatment will be more individualized and based on the actual genetic changes in each person's cancer. Advancements being made in the field of molecular biology, there are extensive genetic testing that help drugs that directly target those changes.



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While precision medicine is expected to become a mainstream medicine in the near future, a part of it is already in practice.

Dr.P K Das said, *"We need to prepare a treatment plan that is most likely to suit the patient with the given genetic changes, this benefits the patients"*.

There are several drugs that have already been approved by the Food and Drug Administration in the US. These drugs directly target genetic changes in the cells, based on the type, size, and the region of the spread of cancer. The use of drugs to target the changes in the DNA is also known as targeted drug therapy

Treatment is possible in early stages and late stage with chemotherapy and targeted therapy in an effective and tolerated way. Early treatment of various cancer like late state lymphoma, testicular cancer will lead to better survival. New therapies like Immunotherapy can also lead to success in late stage of the lungs, kidneys, and mouth cancer. Targeted therapies in late-stage cancer are well tolerated and effective. Accordingly, late-stage cancer, simple and successful treatment can be done. For this it is advisable to consult a cancer physician and surgeon in your area without being frightened or misled by the cancer.

Choose to maintain a healthy lifestyle to reduce your chance of getting cancer.

Avoid alcohol or drink in moderation, eat a healthy diet, Exercise regularly, get regular checkups and talk to your doctor about cancer screening, know your family history of cancer and talk with your doctor about it, limit your time in the sun, apply sunscreen, and wear protective clothing, quit using tobacco. Ask your health care provider for help quitting.

The best way we can manage a cancer is by understanding the early signs and beginning timely management. So, let's fight together.

By creating awareness, we recognise the power of knowledge. We know that every single one of us can make a difference, large or small, and that together we can make real progress in reducing the global impact of cancer.

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